The people who left were mostly Kashmiri Pandits or Brahmins who had a historic connection with the Kashmir Valley, but it also included others, including a few Muslims who wanted to escape the suspicions cast by militants on one side and the Indian armed forces on the other.[65] Hundreds died, before and after 1990, in planned encounters. At the peak of the crisis in 1990, there were also accounts of women being raped. The lack of convictions in hundreds of cases in subsequent decades did little to assuage the feeling of injustice felt by the Kashmiri Pandits.[66] After 1990, some Kashmiri Pandits did go back but most of them remained outside. Hindus' share of population in Kashmir declined from 4 per cent in 1981 to 1.8 per cent in 2001, even though their share of the population in Jammu and Kashmir overall remained the same as in 1961, around 29 percent.[67] Between 1981 and 2001, around 1,20,000 Hindus are estimated to have left the Kashmir valley, on a net-basis.[68]

There are no simple explanations as to how one of the most beautiful places of the world became such a cesspool of hatred and violence in 1990. Kashmir's position as being the key bone of contention between India and Pakistan, leading to conflict and wars, was certainly a driving factor. Suspicions of rigged elections in 1987 and police crackdowns alienated the people to a point where chants of *azadi* (freedom) rang loudly in the late 1980s. Across the border, Pakistan sensed an opportunity to avenge the loss of Bangladesh and began training and arming the Kashmiri youth to fight for freedom, just as India had done with the Bangladeshi youth in 1971. The key difference was that India had responded to a major refugee crisis in 1971, whereas in Pakistan the response was linked closely with elements spreading nascent ideas of global jihad. It was not entirely a coincidence that in the winter of January 1990, when minority Hindus were being killed in Kashmir in cold blood amidst chants of azadi, a similar fate befell the minority Armenian Christians in Baku, the capital of Muslim-majority Azerbaijan, with calls for independence from the USSR. The Kashmir insurgency that took off in 1989 had the blessings of radical mujahideen that were promoted across the border in a bid to counter the USSR's march on Afghanistan in the 1980s. Caught in the crosshairs of international and